



March 15, 2025

Michael Kratsios
Director
Office Science and Technology Policy
Washington, D.C. 20502

Sethuraman Panchanathan
Director
National Science Foundation
Alexandria, VA 22314

Re: Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan

Dear Director Kratsios and Director Panchanathan:

The Security Industry Association (SIA) appreciates the opportunity to submit a response to the Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP) and the National Science Foundation (NSF) on its “Request for Information (RFI) on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan.” We believe the action plan could play a pivotal role in ensuring U.S. leadership in AI that will help secure the benefits of AI driven technologies to society.

About SIA

SIA Represents more than 1,500 companies that provide a wide array of products essential to protecting the physical safety of people property, businesses, schools, and critical infrastructure in the state and throughout the nation, and to bolstering public safety as well as homeland and national security.

We support development and use of AI technologies in ways that are human-centric, ethical and trustworthy and that mitigate potential risks, as well as policies that ensure society to continues to harness the benefits of AI for enhancing safety and security.

AI and Security

AI stands to provide enormous individual, societal and economic benefits in almost every sector. The possibilities of AI are particularly notable in safety and security applications, where AI helps power advanced tools enabling technology users to analyze and respond to information in a substantially quicker and more accurate manner than traditional methods. Associated techniques like machine learning, computer vision, deep learning, and neural networks can dramatically improve the capabilities of security solutions and have been the primary areas of recent technological innovation in our industry, which contributes \$131 billion in direct economic impact and supports over 2 million jobs across the United States.¹

Today, these technologies are enhancing applications for remote and on-site guarding, robotics, cloud computing, biometrics, sensor fusion, video analytics, anomaly recognition, object classification, event

¹ <https://www.securityindustry.org/member-resources/reports-publications/security-industry-economic-impact-report/>.

detection, passive weapons detection, drone detection and mitigation, perimeter security s automated alarm response, traffic and parking garage management, and speeding up security investigations, just to name a few.

Deploying AI-enabled security technologies continues to show results for providing more preventative versus reactionary capabilities in security operations, increasing operational efficiency and providing safer work and leisure environments – with clear and obvious public benefits.

For biometrics in particular, AI-powered software for matching biometric data have transformed many safety and security operations. Widely used biometric identity verification capabilities such as fingerprint or facial recognition support a tremendous volume of online commerce on a daily basis. These tools can help prevent identity theft and fraud, aiding in authentication and verification solutions for account access and financial transactions. These capabilities are also used for physical security such as access control and facility security screening, and even support rapid and contactless travel experiences such as clearing customs and aviation security screening.

AI has enabled the performance of facial recognition technology to reach, and in many cases exceed, automated fingerprint comparison.² End-users are relying on the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) benchmarking³ to choose which technologies and algorithms to use based on accuracy. U.S. Department of Homeland Security (DHS) testing recently found that technology it is using worked more than 99% of the time within fully operational systems, like ID checks for travelers. Suppliers also provide built-in control capabilities and implementation guidance or conditions, including the appropriate level of human review. Indeed, as is the case with AI tools generally, when deployed responsibly and with appropriate human oversight, facial recognition technology has been shown to be more accurate than humans performing the same tasks unaided by the technology.⁴ This also comes with significant public safety and homeland security benefits, including detecting individuals attempting to enter the U.S. illegally.⁵ Software tools utilizing this technology have also become indispensable to investigations of child sexual exploitation and human trafficking, and key to solving many cold cases and violent crimes.⁶

Recommendations

As the AI action plan is developed, we urge you to consider the following principles and recommendations.

1. Bolstering the AI Workforce

The security industry is engaged in efforts to grow its talent pipeline by working with colleges and vocational schools, as well as offering technical training, apprenticeship and certification programs. We strongly support the expansion of hands-on workforce development partnerships between government

² <https://www.securityindustry.org/2022/07/23/what-science-really-says-about-facial-recognition-accuracy-and-bias-concerns/>

³ <https://www.nist.gov/programs-projects/face-technology-evaluations-frtefate>.

⁴ <https://www.pnas.org/doi/10.1073/pnas.1721355115>

⁵ See <https://www.cbp.gov/travel/biometrics>.

⁶ SIA has collected reported success stories here - <https://www.securityindustry.org/2020/07/16/facial-recognition-success-stories-showcase-positive-use-cases-of-the-technology/>.

and industry to help address the current skills shortage, including policies that make it easier to use federal education grants, loans, and tax benefits to pursue these opportunities outside of traditional degree programs.

2. Supporting Small Businesses and Start-Ups

Fostering an environment that promotes technological innovation is imperative to recruit and retain the workforce essential to AI, and to strengthen the position of small businesses and start-ups to compete globally. The number of AI-focused start-ups in the security industry has grown exponentially within the current “open regulatory environment,” where innovators are encouraged to experiment and invest in research and development.

3. Ensuring Both the Availability and Responsible use of Data

The availability of data is critical both to AI development and to the effectiveness of AI tools that analyze it. When personal data is involved, it could impact privacy. A comprehensive national data privacy law could help ensure robust protections while allowing for the creation, collection, processing and retention of data needed for AI development and deployment – so long as it is crafted appropriately and thoroughly preempts divergent state laws. Consumers directly benefit when data is used to enhance safety and security. We must ensure any AI or privacy rules do not render such technologies unusable, impractical or undermined.

4. Facilitating Public-Private Partnerships for AI Testing and Evaluation

Some AI systems clearly require extensive testing due to their impact on homeland and national security, and public safety.⁷ This can include biometric identification systems, large language models for critical applications, autonomous defense systems and surveillance-related technologies. The Administration should consider additional testing programs for select technologies, as well as requiring AI developers to account for the origin and lineage of their AI models to prevent the potential use of compromised models from adversaries. This would help mitigate risk from hostile alternations (data poisoning) that could compromise AI systems.

Additionally, the Administration should increase resources for key ongoing testing and evaluation programs activities within the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) the Department of Homeland Security Science and Technology Directorate (DHS S&T) related to AI, and consider additional resources to these agencies as well as the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) and the Intelligence Advanced Research Projects Activity (IARPA) facilitate studying the performance of commercial security-related AI technologies in real-world settings.

5. Commonsense Governance Approaches

A risk-based approach is consistent with the federal government’s longstanding approach to emerging technology, including through the Congressionally mandated AI Risk Management Framework (AI RMF),

⁷ For example, DHS Management Directive 026-11 requires the agency to perform independent performance assessments on face capture and face recognition systems.

as well as its accompanying document, the AI RMF Playbook.⁸ The AI RMF is a voluntary, flexible framework for organizations to mitigate risks when developing and deploying AI tools. NIST has spent years developing the AI RMF at the direction of Congress, and during this development, NIST worked with industry and aligned its guidance with existing industry standards.⁹

Regarding any regulatory approach to governance, it is important to consider existing rules and regulations first, as many processes and decisions aided by AI are already covered by existing laws, and new concerns regarding AI could be addressed within or build upon those frameworks. If it is clear additional policies are needed, any regulatory approaches should be technology-neutral and use-case specific, and appropriately focused on sector-specific technology applications that are truly high-risk as far as concrete harms to individuals. Relatedly, there is potential for state governments to create a patchwork of broadly scoped AI policies that conflict or are inconsistent. To ensure the U.S. retains its leadership position on AI, the U.S. government should work to prevent this type of outcome which could stifle innovation and growth.

Conclusion

SIA is committed to engaging with our industry and other stakeholders to ensure the benefits of AI can be fully and responsibly harnessed to improve the lives of Americans and help solve some of our toughest challenges.

Given the far-reaching and long-term strategic importance of AI-driven technologies to the U.S. it is imperative as a nation that we get the AI Action plan right. We appreciate the opportunity to respond to the RFI and are ready to provide any additional assistance the Administration might need as this important work continues.

Respectfully Submitted,

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⁸ <https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/ai/NIST.AI.100-1.pdf>; https://airc.nist.gov/AI_RM_F_Knowledge_Base/Playbook

⁹ https://airc.nist.gov/AI_RM_F_Knowledge_Base/Roadmap